

Family Meliphagidae

Honeyeaters

Length $3\frac{3}{4}$ –12½ in (9.5–32 cm)

Species 187

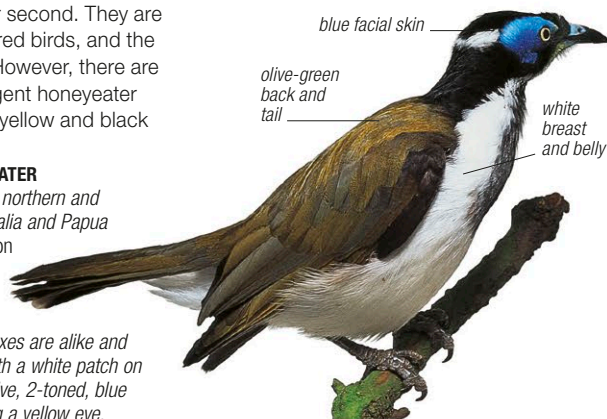


Found mainly in Papua New Guinea, Australia, Asia, and the Pacific Islands, honeyeaters are mostly nectar- and fruit-eating birds with a characteristic brush tongue adapted to nectar-feeding. This tongue can be extended into nectar about 10 times per second. They are generally dull-colored birds, and the sexes are similar. However, there are exceptions: the regent honeyeater is brighter, with its yellow and black

plumage, and the sexes among scarlet honeyeaters differ—males are red and females are brown. Members of this family vary greatly in size. Some resemble warblers or thrushes, others look like hummingbirds, and the larger honeyeaters could almost be mistaken for magpies. Some of these birds do not have feathers on their face and develop wattles. All are found in wooded habitats, with only a few descending to the ground to feed. Outside the breeding season, these birds often migrate in search of flowering trees.

BLUE-FACED HONEYEATER

Distributed across the northern and eastern sides of Australia and Papua New Guinea, *Entomyzon cyanotis* is 12 in (30 cm) long and is found in open forest and farmland. Both sexes are alike and have a black head, with a white patch on the nape, and distinctive, 2-toned, blue facial skin surrounding a yellow eye.



Family Acanthizidae

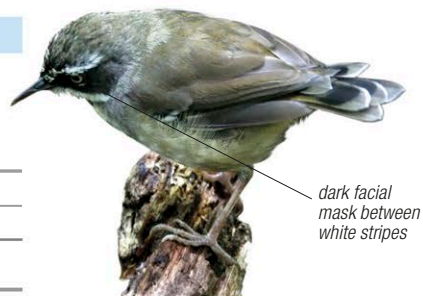
Australasian warblers

Length $3\frac{1}{2}$ –5 in (9–13 cm)

Species 65



This family is centered on New Guinea and Australia, but a few species occur westward in the Philippines and Indonesia or eastward on Pacific Islands and New Zealand. Many species have very localized distribution ranges. This fact, however, helps in identification, because similar species can occur in geographically distinct areas. Usually olive, brown, or yellow, the sexes among Australian warblers are similar. Many species are insectivores, while some feed on seeds. They are often seen in



WHITE BROWED SCRUBWREN

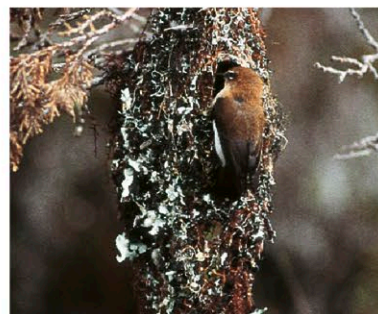
A widespread Australian species, *Sericornis frontalis* is a dozen or so noisy scrubwrens of dense thickets. The white-browed scrubwren has a rich and varied voice, and can also mimic.

pairs, in family parties, and sometimes in mixed-species flocks. Most species do not migrate. The nest made by these birds is a dome of plant fibers, often with a "porch." Females lay 2–4 white, sometimes spotted, eggs. Incubation and fledging each take 15–20 days.



BROWN THORNBILL

Found in eastern and southeastern Australia and Tasmania, *Acanthiza pusilla* is 4 in (10 cm) long, and has narrow streaks on its gray throat. It forages among the twigs of lower branches and has a variety of calls, among them a scolding note. The nest is built low down in the undergrowth.



BROWN-BREASTED GERYGONE

About $3\frac{1}{2}$ in (9 cm) in size, *Gerygone ruficollis* is found in primary forest in the mountains of New Guinea, at heights of 3,650–10,900 ft (1,100–3,300 m). Its song is a distinctive and lengthy series of high-pitched whistles, and its nest a pendant, globular structure with a side entrance.



TUI

Endemic to New Zealand, where it is found in native forest and scrub, *Prosthemadera novaeseelandiae* has glossy black plumage with a purple-green iridescent color and 2 white throat tufts. An energetic bird with a rich, melodic song, it feeds on nectar, fruit, and insects. The male—12 in (30 cm) long—is larger than the female.

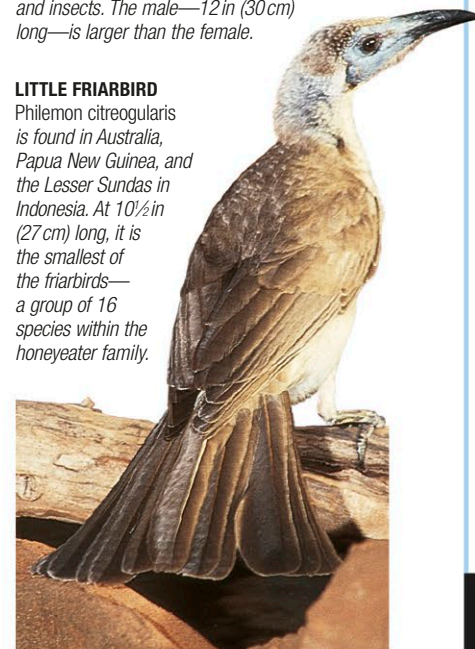


NOISY MINER

Found only in eastern Australia, including Tasmania, the noisy, gregarious *Manorina melanoccephala* is locally called the soldierbird. It is 10 in (26 cm) long and both the sexes look alike. It breeds in colonies from June to December.

LITTLE FRIARBIRD

Philemon citreogularis is found in Australia, Papua New Guinea, and the Lesser Sunda Islands. At $10\frac{1}{2}$ in (27 cm) long, it is the smallest of the friarbirds—a group of 16 species within the honeyeater family.



Family Maluridae

Australasian wrens

Length $4\frac{3}{4}$ –7½ in (12–19 cm)

Species 29



Found in Australia, Papua New Guinea, and eastern Indonesia, Australasian wrens are brightly colored birds that hold their tails upright or over their back in the same way as wrens (see p.361). The metallic colors of their plumage include blues, purples, reds, blacks, and whites. Sexes generally differ. Many fairy-wrens are good singers, some being good mimics as well. They hunt for insects and their larvae through the underbrush, and are often found in flocks.

Their nest is usually domed,



SOUTHERN EMU-WREN

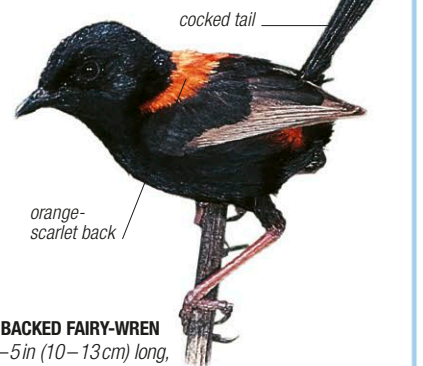
Notable for its very long tail, formed of 6 delicate feathers, *Stipiturus malachurus* is 6–7½ in (15–19 cm) long. It occurs along the coastal strip of southern Australia and in Tasmania.

and is made of grass, spiders' webs, and a lining of feathers and plant down. Fairy-wrens lay 2–4 whitish, speckled eggs, which are incubated for 12–15 days; the nestlings fledge in 10–12 days.



SUPERB FAIRY-WREN

Also known as the blue wren, *Malurus cyaneus* is found in southeast Australia and Tasmania. It is 5–5½ in (13–14 cm) long, and has a tinny song.



RED-BACKED FAIRY-WREN

At 4–5 in (10–13 cm) long, *Malurus melanocephalus* is the smallest fairy-wren. Found in northern and eastern Australia, it occupies habitats varying from tall grass to plantations and gardens, and breeds from November to March.